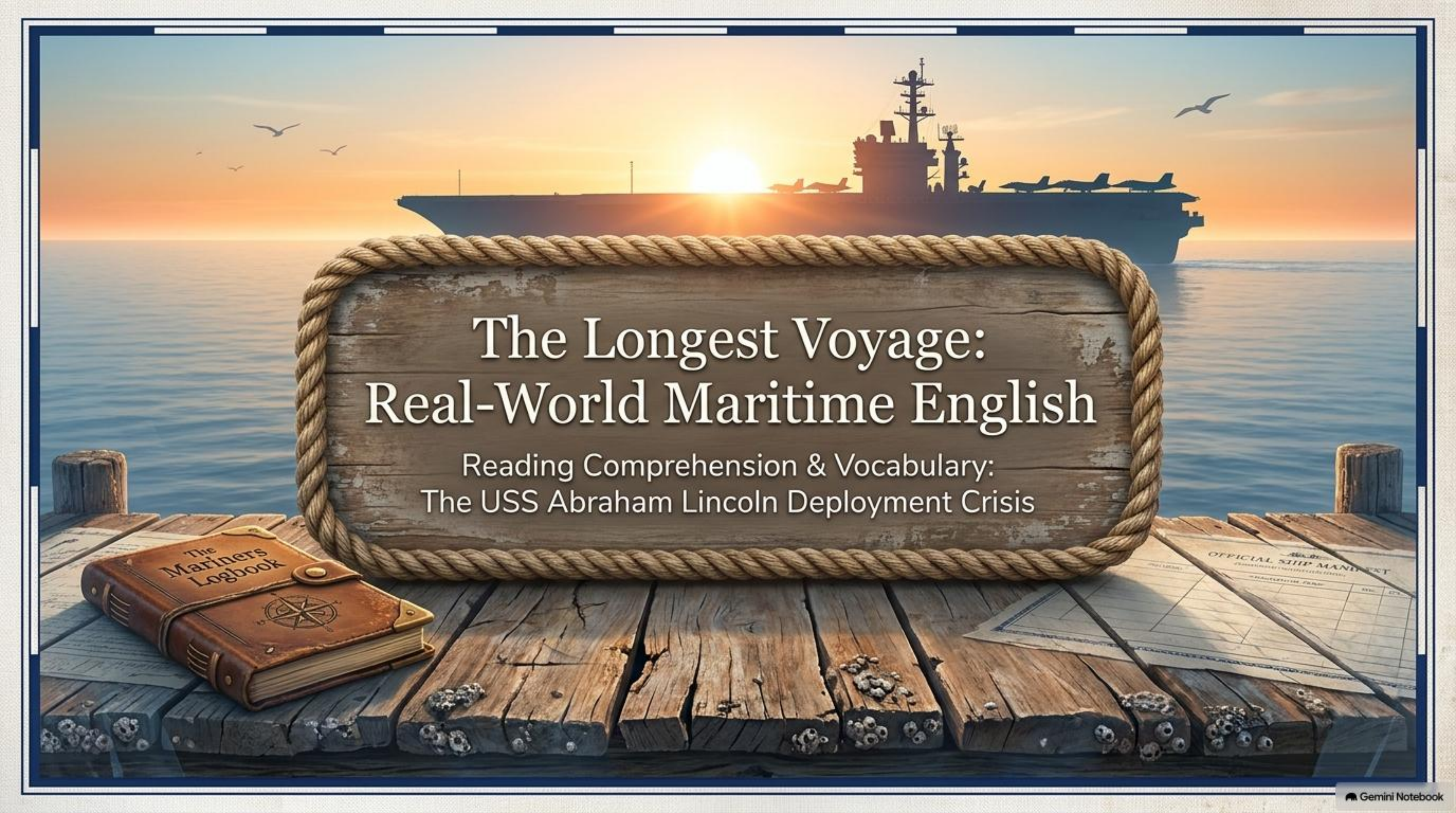




The Longest Voyage: Real-World Maritime English

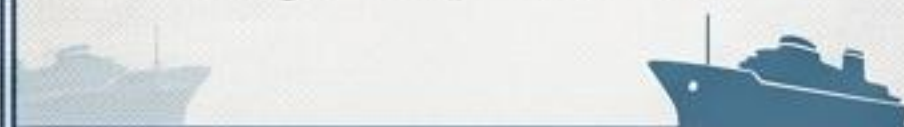
Reading Comprehension & Vocabulary:
The USS Abraham Lincoln Deployment Crisis



The USS Abraham Lincoln carries over 5,000 sailors and marines.

It is currently deployed in the Middle East, conducting combat operations tied to the US-Israel-Iran conflict.

Vessel (n.):
A large ship or boat.



Aircraft Carrier (n.):
A massive warship with a full-length flight deck for planes.



Crew (n.):
The group of people who work on and operate a ship.





Deployment (n.):
The assignment of military personnel to a specific location or task.

Consecutively (adv.):
Following one after another without interruption.

In its ninth month at sea, the crew has spent a modern-record 250 consecutive days without touching land.

Originally intended for the Pacific, the ship was redirected and its return delayed multiple times.

Port of Call (n. phrase):
A place where a ship stops on a voyage.

Representative Mike Levin reported severe breakdowns in basic living standards aboard the ship:



Hygiene: Moldy showers, broken toilets, and laundry machines broken for weeks.



Supplies: Long stretches with no hot water, soap, deodorant, or toothpaste.



Meals: Food heavily rationed (e.g., half a cup of rice and two tortillas per meal).

Rationed (adj.):
Limited to a fixed portion, usually during a shortage.

Moldy (adj.):
Covered with a fungus that grows in damp conditions.

Amenities (n.):
Useful or desirable features of a facility (like hot water).

The physical strain has fueled an escalating mental health crisis. Military papers report multiple thwarted attempts by sailors to jump overboard.

Quote 1:
One sailor texted his spouse that "he hopes he doesn't wake up tomorrow."

Quote 2: A 13-year / 3-year veteran feared seeking help, believing his burnout would lead to a ruined career and a dishonorable discharge.

Action: In one incident, a crew member physically grabbed a fellow sailor to prevent them from jumping.

Overboard (adv.):
Over the side of a ship and into the water.

Thwarted (v.):
Prevented someone from accomplishing something.

Dishonorable Discharge (n. phrase):
Being fired from the military for bad conduct.

Over 200 worried family members gathered in San Diego to confront Acting Navy Secretary Hung Cao. The emotional meeting highlighted a growing divide between the families on shore and the leadership in command.

The Grievance:

One woman explicitly told leadership that the Navy had “broken trust” with the families.

The Warning:

Rep. Jason Crow warned that the strain is “building week by week.”

Town Hall (n.):

A public meeting where leaders answer questions from citizens.

Vented (v.):

Expressed a strong emotion, usually anger or frustration.

Trust (n.):

Firm belief in the reliability or truth of someone.

A Tale of Two Tides: Competing Perspectives

The Crew & Families' Reports

Reports cite “no hot water, broken toilets,” and a rising mental health crisis. Rep. Levin insists the country owes sailors basic dignity.

Leadership's Official Response

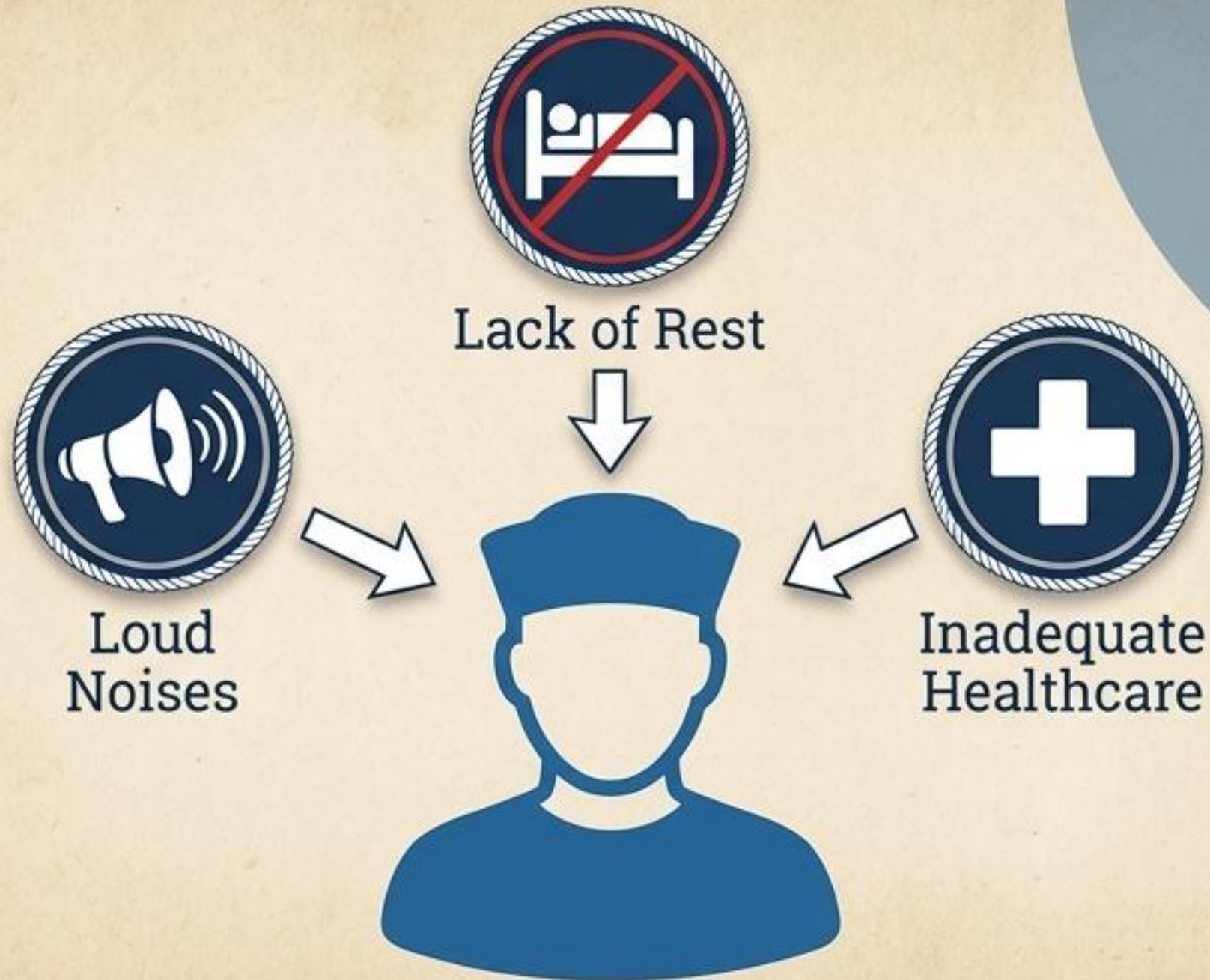
Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth previously dismissed reports as “fake news.” A Navy official stated there is “continuous access to clean water, functional AC and healthy meal options,” with no identified increase in suicidal ideation.

Dismissed (v.): Rejected an idea as false or unworthy of consideration.

Ideation (n.): The formation of ideas or concepts (e.g., suicidal thoughts).

Functional (adj.): Working correctly; operating as expected.

A 2025 study on active-duty Navy personnel identified unique stress factors on deployments. Almost half of surveyed sailors reported they do not receive adequate help coping with stress at sea, concluding that improved healthcare access is urgently needed.



Strain (n.):

A severe or excessive demand on strength or resources.

Inadequate (adj.):

Lacking the quality or quantity required.

Coping (v.):

Dealing effectively with something difficult

The Mariner's Logbook

Despite the criticism, the Navy maintains that the health and well-being of every Lincoln sailor remains a priority. They highlight a “comprehensive support network” available onboard:

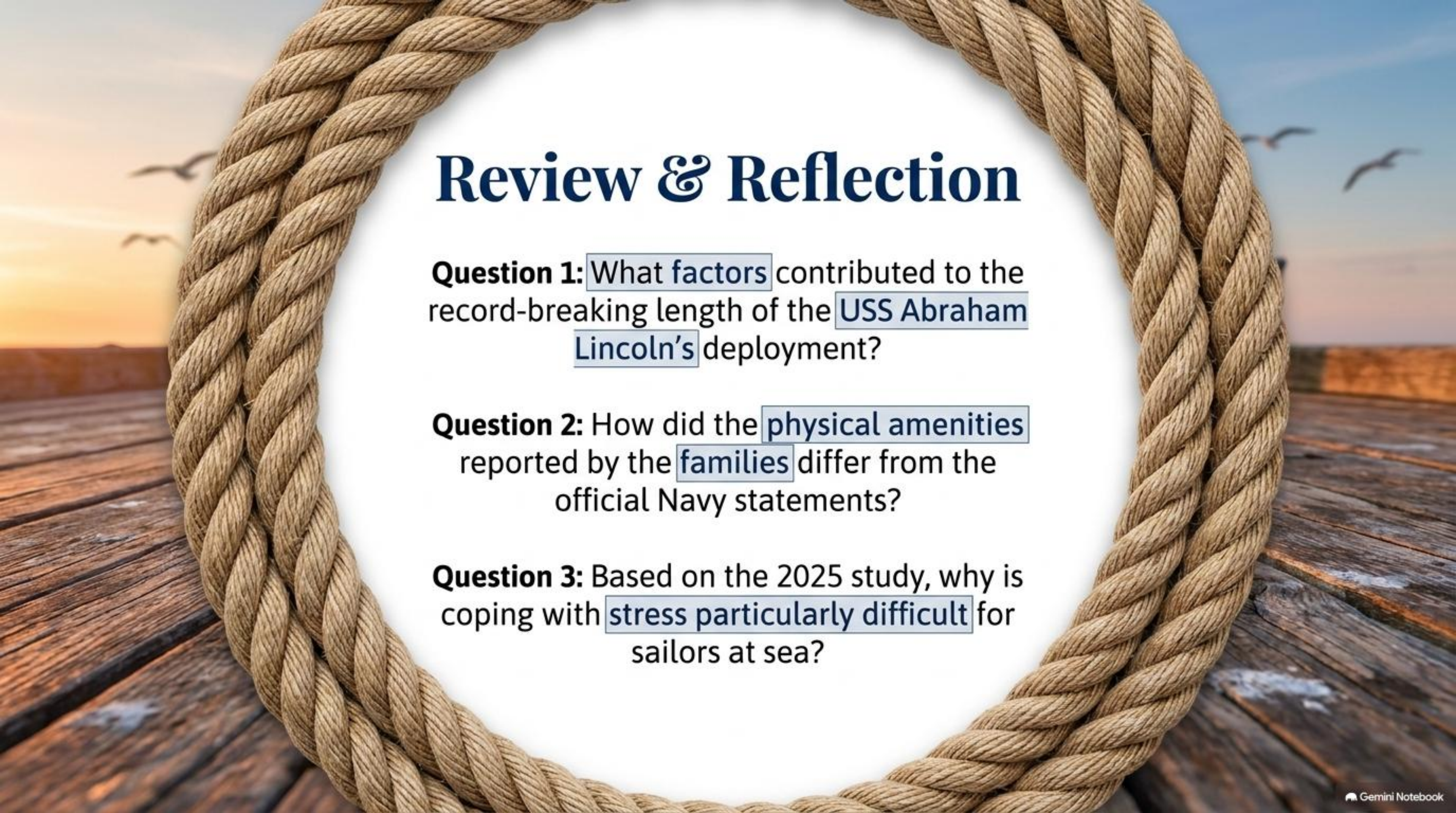
- Religious professionals and Chaplains.
- Medical staff.
- Onboard deployment-resilience counselors.

Resilience (n.):
The capacity to recover quickly from difficulties.

Chaplain (n.):
A religious representative attached to a secular institution like the military.

Comprehensive (adj.):
Complete; including all or nearly all elements.





Review & Reflection

Question 1: What factors contributed to the record-breaking length of the USS Abraham Lincoln's deployment?

Question 2: How did the physical amenities reported by the families differ from the official Navy statements?

Question 3: Based on the 2025 study, why is coping with stress particularly difficult for sailors at sea?